is concerned but it is worth it given the extensive feature list. The software sports one of the neatest interfaces, making it easy to access different features. The access to the submenu is through the main menu and it's very difficult to make mistakes with this software. The software comes bundled with Direct CD, which allows you to drag and drop files from any Windows Explorer. To increase audio and video quality, Easy CD has built-in filtering software.

Creating an audio CD or video CD takes just one click. Copying a CD using the CD Copier option is an easy task to perform with the Easy Creator 5. For those who regularly take backups on CDs will be pleased with Take Two backup tool which takes backup and even looks up for the update on your drive. Like other CD burning software, Easy CD Creator has an online Web Check Tool and a CD label creator.

Verdict: *This is one of the best designed and feature-rich CD burning software available.*

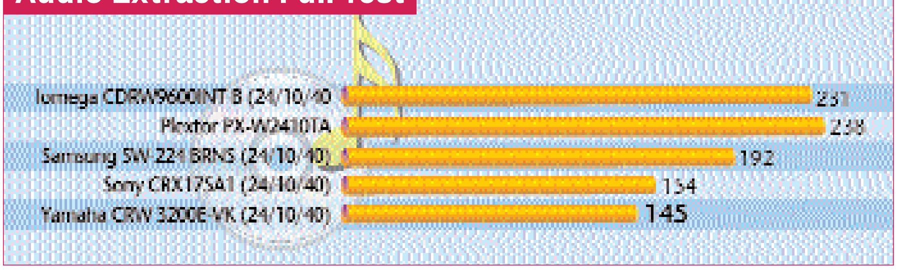
Prassi PrimoCD Plus: This one has a relatively simple interface. It has an install size of just 2.23 MB and no memory-hogging tray icons. Instead, it has very small buttons that take just a few attempts to get accustomed to.

The software took very little time to install. Burning a data or audio and video CD is very easy as there are buttons for them on the main interface. This speeds up the process by eliminating the scrolling time. A box at the bottom of the PrimoCD Plus starter displays appropriate messages to guide the user.

Clicking on the graphical representation of the media in the recorder brings up Disc Explorer and the Properties menu displaying information regarding the media. It also has a help file in HTML format which guides you through each step. Plus there is a list of supported formats and a comprehensive error message list. The software has good support on the Net and is a good choice for those looking for a stable and hassle-free CD writing software.

Verdict: *This is a well developed CD burning software but the interface could do with a facelift*.

Audio Extraction Full Test



best and the worst in a CD-Writer. Take for example the Acer CRW 1610A and the Krypton CD-Writer, both of which failed this test. Also, the Acer CRW 2010A took over 2 minutes extra to burn the CD-RW.

Apart from these glitches, the usual suspects were at it again, fighting neck and neck for the top spot. This time around, the 20x sibling of the Yamaha writers took the top spot, completing the test in a record 471 seconds (7 minutes 51 seconds), followed closely by big brother, Yamaha CRW 3200E-VK which burnt the RW in a nifty 473 seconds (7 minutes 53 seconds).

Using it like a CD-ROM drive

There are some things that you can't ignore when it comes to a drive's performance. True, these drives were not built to read and transfer data as fast as possible. What they were built to do was to write data onto a media as fast as possible. But the fundamentals of the basic drive mechanism remain the same and these aspects of a drive cannot be separated whether it is a CD-ROM drive or a CD-Writer. A drive performing exceptionally when it comes to reading data but failing to perform in the writing tests would be rare. Nevertheless, this batch of tests will give you a fair idea of the build quality and drive performance.

We used an audio CD with 14 tracks totalling 64 minutes 2 seconds for the audio extraction test. The LG GCE-8160B ripped the CD in only 138 seconds (2 minutes 18 seconds), beating the formidable Yamaha CRW 3200E-VK by over 7 seconds.

Glossary

Cross-talk: A measure of the amount of interference coming from neighbouring pit tracks on a CD. As track pitch is tightened (when tracks are packed closer together to put more data on a disc), cross-talk increases. A maximum value of 50 per cent is allowed by Red Book specifications.

Mastering: The process of creating a stamper or set of stampers to be used in the injection moulding stage of manufacturing compact discs. During this process a digital signal from a computer is used to guide a laser beam which etches a pattern of 'pits and lands' (in the case of CDs) or a continuous groove (for CD-Rs) onto a highly polished glass disc coated with photoresist. This 'glass master' is then cured (developed) with ultraviolet light and rinsed off, and a metal (nickel or silver) mould is electroformed on top of it. This mould is removed and then electroplated with a nickle alloy to create one or more stampers to be used in the injection moulding machine to press the data into the polycarbonate substrate of CDs, or the guiding groove into the substrate of CD-Rs.

Media or 'blanks': CD-Recordable media are the discs used to record digital information with a special recorder and premastering software on a computer. These discs are made of a polycarbonate substrate, a layer of organic dye, a metalised reflective layer, and a protective lacquer coating. Some discs also have an additional protective coating over the metalised layer, while others have a printable surface silkscreened on them.

Organic dye: The data layer of CD-R discs is made from either cyanine or phthalocyanine dye which is melted during the recording process. Where the dye is melted, it becomes opaque or refractive, scattering the reading laser beam so it is not reflected back into the reader's sensors. The difference between reflected and non-reflected light is interpreted by the player as a binary signal.

Pits and lands: In a 'pressed' or mass-replicated CD, the bumps and grooves that represent the binary data on a disc's substrate are pressed into it during manufacture. CD-R discs do not have true pits and lands, but the un-melted, clear areas and melted, opaque places in the dye layer fulfil the same function as pits and lands on a pressed disc.